DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Why Can There Only Be One God?

Derech Hashem 1:1:5-6

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 1, Chapter 1, paragraphs 5-6 (end of the chapter) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 31 December 2020

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Review of the first five principles

The Rabbi reviewed what had been learned so far about Hakadosh Barukh Hu:

1. He exists: a First Being, without beginning and eternal, who continuously creates all of existence.
2. The only thing we can know of Him is that He is perfect. Everything else we say describes how He relates to us. The Ramhal could prove all this from philosophy and physics, but relies on the tradition going back to Sinai.
3. His existence is necessary: a universe without Him is impossible.
4. That necessity is independent. The Torah also has necessary existence, but it depends on Hashem; His does not depend on anything.
5. His existence is simple, with no multiplicity. He has every perfection, but not as separate parts: they all form one entity, which is God. Even a human with every good trait would still be a combination of parts.

Beyond our grasp (end of paragraph 5)

The Ramhal admits he almost has no words for this. Our imagination only grasps natural things with boundaries, and for human beings everything is compartmentalised. Do not draw a parallel from what you see in people to Hashem: they are incomparable. Just because we have no concept of "everything in one" does not mean it does not exist in Him.

The Rabbi gave an example from Mount Sinai, where the people "saw the voices," and the Midrash says they could see what is heard and hear what is seen. To us that makes no sense, since seeing and hearing are separate. "But if it's all one thing, then it can make sense." Sometimes, when we speak of Hashem, we must let go of what we see in our current existence.

The Ramhal adds that this, too, is both tradition and logic. Logic dictates that there must be a being free of all the limits of nature, of all deficiency, of all multiplicity and of any relation to other things, which is the true cause of all existence. Without such a being, neither the

existence of creation nor its continued existence (since Hashem does not just create once, He keeps creating) would be possible.

Paragraph 6: He is One

The sixth and final principle: Hashem must be one, and not more than one.

Paragraphs 3 and 4 established that His existence is necessary and independent. It is impossible for there to be two such beings. Imagine two gods, each necessary and each without limitation: "One's going to limit the other. It's impossible." Once the first five principles are established, there cannot be another being with the same qualities.

The Ramhal adds that although other beings do exist, they exist only because Hashem wills them to. All of existence depends on Him and nothing exists independently. This sixth principle is Yihud Hashem, the unity and oneness of Hashem.

Questions. A participant asked about the words "efes zulato," "there is nothing besides Him," and about the plural form Elohim. The Rabbi clarified that when the Ramhal speaks of other "existing things" (nimsaim), he means created beings, like you and me, not other gods. They exist, but only in dependence on Him.

The Ramhal sums up the six root principles: Hashem's existence, His perfection, His necessary existence, its independence, His simplicity and His unity.

Unity and the golden calf

How could Bnei Yisrael, who had heard Hashem at Sinai only forty days earlier, including "You shall have no other gods," make a golden calf? The Rabbi brought the explanation that it is illogical to think they were serving an idol after seeing Hashem. Rather, they believed Hashem must be served through an intermediary. Moshe, through his greatness, had filled that role, and when he was gone they felt they needed another. The calf was meant as a means of serving Hashem, yet even that is avodah zarah: we go straight to Hakadosh Barukh Hu, not through other beings or objects.

The Rabbi explained why this remains relevant: the unity of Hashem is hard to feel, so it is easier to lean on crutches, such as treating a human figure as a go-between to God, because he is tangible.

Charms, the mezuzah and holiness

The same applies to segulot and charms: a red string on the wrist, a blue hand or a hamsa. If seeing a hamsa reminds you that Hashem is in control and no one can harm you without Him, wonderful. But "probably nobody does that today." When people believe "the red string's protecting me," that is avodah zarah, the golden calf again, and it contradicts the sixth principle. Asked about astrology, the Rabbi said the Rambam held it to be both a false science and forbidden.

Why do we have a mezuzah? A participant answered: to remind us of Hashem. The Rabbi agreed, and cited the Rosh as writing that those who think the mezuzah was given as protection are fools, and for such a person it gives no protection. Hashem gave us the mezuzah so that every time we leave the house we remember what is in it, the unity of

Hashem. When you live your life with that, you are under Divine Providence rather than randomness, and then you are protected. "There's nothing intrinsic in the mezuzah."

He drew a general principle: holy things are not intrinsically holy. The Malbim asks why, after the revelation at Sinai, the people were told they could now go up the mountain. Moshe wanted them to go up so they would not think the mountain itself was special and that prayer there was higher. "This is a regular mountain." Kedushah comes from Hashem's presence and from our preparation, and when it goes, it goes. The mezuzah, tefillin and the Shema morning and evening all remind us that there is only one power in the world.

Yaakov's Shema

In the previous week's parashah, Yosef and Yaakov meet after 22 years. The verse says Yosef kissed Yaakov, implying Yaakov did not kiss Yosef. Rashi explains that Yaakov was saying Shema. The famous question: if it was the time for Shema, why was Yosef not saying it, and if not, why was Yaakov?

The Rabbi's answer: "It's one thing to believe it, it's another thing to see it." Yosef had already seen how everything over twenty years came from Hashem: why he was sold and brought to Egypt, so that he could feed the whole region. Yaakov had only believed it, while still grieving and struggling. Now, seeing Yosef, the whole jigsaw puzzle fell into place, and he said Shema: not only "I believe it," but "I see it, I feel it now."

Simplicity and free will

Finally, the Rabbi used the simplicity of Hashem to explain the Rambam's answer to the famous question: if Hashem knows the future, how do we have free will? And if He does not know it, He is not perfect.

The Rambam says the question arises only because we live in past, present and future. Imagine someone watching you walk over a bridge right now: he knows exactly what you are doing, yet you are still choosing freely, because it is happening in the present. For Hashem there is no past, present and future: "It's all one big thing." It is very hard for us to grasp, but once we accept that Hashem operates in simplicity, the question becomes reconcilable.

The Rabbi encouraged everyone to review the six points over Shabbat. The series would now meet Mondays and Thursdays, and move from discussing Hashem to the purpose of creation: why we exist and why we live.

Summary

- The simplicity of Hashem is beyond our grasp, like "seeing the voices" at Sinai, but it is both tradition and logic.
- Paragraph 6: there can only be one necessary, unlimited being, and everything else exists only because He wills it.
- Seeking intermediaries, whether the golden calf or modern charms, contradicts the unity of Hashem.
- The mezuzah, tefillin and Shema are reminders of Hashem's unity, not amulets; holiness is not intrinsic to objects.

- Because there is no time for Hashem, His knowledge does not contradict our free will.

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